LYMPHATICS AND LACTEALS.

Lymphatic vessels are found in almost every part of the organism, arising at the surface of membranes and in the tissue of organs; they carry into the veins the lymph from respective parts. The lymphatics are of two orders,—*i.e.*, superficial and deep seated; they often cross each other in their tortuous course, and their anastomoses are very numerous. Without a very definite knowledge of the remote arrangements of the vessels, we can only say that all the lymphatics of the body ultimately discharge themselves at the junction of the subclavian and internal jugular veins.

Fig. 17.

The lacteals are the absorbants which originate in the small intestines, and supply the mammary glands with milk during the period of gestation. During digestion these vessels contain a transparent, colorless lymph.

Whilst intestinal absorption is progressing after a meal containing fatty ingredients, the lacteals may be seen as white opaque vessels, distended with milky chyle; but the presence of chyle is only transitory. The nutritive materials soon pass by catalytic transformation into other forms, and become assimilated to the pre-existing elements of the circulating fluids, and belong to the great system of nutrition, absorption, re-absorption, secretion, and elimination.